

Senior AI Engineer & Researcher, Ph.D. in Machine Learning & Distributed Systems

Senior AI engineer and researcher with 11+ years building production systems across cybersecurity, defense, and simulation, now leading enterprise AI strategy and applied GenAI at Avion. Completed a Ph.D. (August 2025) in Machine Learning and Distributed Systems at Embry-Riddle Aeronautical University, with three first-author IEEE Access publications on Proof-of-Learning and model watermarking. My work centers on **verifiable, trustworthy machine learning**: systems whose behavior can be proven rather than assumed, engineered for domains where failure is not an option.

Deep foundation in systems programming (C, C++, Scala) and distributed architecture, combined with hands-on ML-security research. Experienced in leading engineering teams, owning complex technical deliverables end to end, and translating original research into production-grade systems.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Languages:** C, C++, Scala, Python, Go, Java, TypeScript, JavaScript
- **Systems and real-time:** multithreading, async I/O, low-latency, backpressure, Linux, networking, Boost, Qt/QML
- **Distributed and data:** gRPC, Protobuf, Redis, PostgreSQL, REST, real-time data pipelines
- **Machine learning & AI:** PyTorch, TensorFlow, scikit-learn, deep learning, LLMs, retrieval-augmented generation (RAG), AI agents, on-prem and air-gapped model deployment, federated and distributed ML training, large-scale model evaluation; trustworthy and verifiable ML (model watermarking, Proof-of-Learning, adversarial robustness, model provenance)
- **Web and UI:** Svelte, TypeScript, HTML, CSS, Tailwind
- **DevOps:** Docker, GitLab CI/CD, Jenkins, Git

EXPERIENCE

Avion Full Flight Simulators AMSTERDAM, NETHERLANDS

Senior Software Engineer Oct 2023 – Present

- Lead Avion’s enterprise AI strategy: authored the AI adoption roadmap and a three-tier architecture spanning air-gapped on-prem LLMs, a governed cloud-LLM API tier, and edge deployment.
- Designed a suite of retrieval-augmented and autonomous AI agents (engineering-knowledge copilot with grounded citations and change-impact analysis, autonomous repository agent, RFP accelerator, training-debrief writer) and built the strategy portal end to end (Flask, SQLite, Docker, GitLab CI/CD).
- Developed real-time simulator software in C, C++, and Scala.
- Built a low-latency data pipeline ingesting simulator telemetry, normalizing and serializing to JSON and Protobuf, caching in Redis, persisting in PostgreSQL, and serving the frontend via gRPC and HTTP; sustained approximately 50 GB/s real-time throughput using batching and bounded-queue backpressure.
- Built web applications for the Avion Cloud Environment to monitor, configure, and diagnose core simulator components using TypeScript, Svelte, Scala, Python, and gRPC.
- Containerized and deployed services with Docker; automated testing and deployments via GitLab CI/CD.
- Applied multithreading and async I/O patterns with backpressure to meet rigorous real-time requirements.

Embry-Riddle Aeronautical University, Daytona Beach FLORIDA, USA

Graduate Research Assistant Aug 2021 – Aug 2025

- Advisor: Dr. Kenji Yoshigoe. Dissertation: Enhancing Proof-of-Learning Security Against Spoofing Attacks Using Model Watermarking.
- Conducted original research on verifiable, trustworthy machine learning across proof-of-learning, model watermarking, and adversarial robustness, with three first-author papers in IEEE Access.
- Journal referee for IEEE Access; program committee member for NLPAICS 2026 (University of Alicante).

Havelsan ANKARA, TURKEY

Software Team Lead Nov 2020 – Aug 2021

Havelsan DLP enterprise Data Leakage Prevention product.

- Led a team of 14 engineers (developers, QA, DevOps, support) delivering endpoint security software.
- Developed and maintained core features of the endpoint agent in C, C++, Java, and Go.
- Coordinated with product and business stakeholders to align delivery with roadmap objectives.

STM Defence Technologies

ANKARA, TURKEY

Expert Software Engineer

Feb 2019 – Nov 2020

Kargu Autonomous Attack UAV and Togan Autonomous Reconnaissance UAV.

- Contributed to mission-control and ground-control unit architecture in C++11 with Boost and Qt.
- Designed and implemented Power-On and Continuous Built-In Tests for system reliability validation.
- Worked with cross-functional teams to meet military-grade engineering and safety standards.

Comodo Cybersecurity

ANKARA, TURKEY

Expert Software Engineer

Jul 2014 – Feb 2019

Comodo Dome Secure Web Gateway, Comodo Patch Manager, and the Comodo Dragon browser.

- Led design and development of Windows services and applications in C++17 with Boost and WinAPI.
- Established unit testing and code-review practices; implemented CI/CD pipelines with Jenkins.
- Developed statistical reporting modules and advanced browser security features.

EDUCATION

Embry-Riddle Aeronautical University, Daytona Beach

FLORIDA, USA

Ph.D. in Electrical Engineering and Computer Science

Aug 2021 – Aug 2025

- Dissertation: Enhancing Proof-of-Learning Security Against Spoofing Attacks Using Model Watermarking. Advisor: Dr. Kenji Yoshigoe; committee included IEEE Fellow Dr. Houbing Song.

Middle East Technical University (METU)

ANKARA, TURKEY

Master of Science in Cyber Security

2015 – 2019

- Thesis: Automatic Detection of Cyber Security Events from Turkish Twitter Stream and Newspaper Data

Middle East Technical University (METU)

ANKARA, TURKEY

Bachelor of Science in Computer Engineering

2010 – 2014

Anadolu University

ESKISEHIR, TURKEY

Bachelor of Business Administration

2012 – 2017

PUBLICATIONS

- Ural, O. and Yoshigoe, K. (2025). SecurePoL: Integration of Watermarking With Proof-of-Learning to Enhance Security Against Spoofing Attacks. *IEEE Access*, vol. 13, pp. 213067–213091.
- Ural, O. and Yoshigoe, K. (2024). Enhancing Security of Proof-of-Learning against Spoofing Attacks using Feature-Based Model Watermarking. *IEEE Access*.
- Ural, O. and Yoshigoe, K. (2023). Survey on Blockchain-Enhanced Machine Learning. *IEEE Access*, pp. 145331–145362.
- Ural, O. and Acarturk, C. (2021). Automatic Detection of Cyber Security Events from Turkish Twitter Stream and Newspaper Data. ICISSP 2021.
- Ural, O. (2025). Enhancing Proof-of-Learning Security Against Spoofing Attacks Using Model Watermarking. Doctoral dissertation, Embry-Riddle Aeronautical University.

For full list and citation metrics: Google Scholar profile.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

- **Journal Referee:** IEEE Access and peer-reviewed journals in security, machine learning, distributed systems, and blockchain.

- **Program Committee Member (2026):** 2nd Workshop on NLP Applied to Information and Cyber Security (NLPAICS 2026), University of Alicante, Spain.
 - **Reviewer:** IEEE and ACM conferences in security, machine learning, and distributed systems.
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AWARDS AND HONORS

- TUBITAK National Project Competition, First Prize, June 2014.
- Middle East Technical University Graduation Projects Competition, Second Prize, June 2014.